COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Nordic Head at Cognizant Sees Significant Growth Potential in AI-Driven Automation for Insurance Industry

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
25 Sep 2025	27 Jun 2025	Customer	Business-Led	DEEPOPINION

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the implementation and scaling of agentic AI platforms in enterprise settings, focusing on insurance claims processing and BPO operations. Topics include technology choices, operational impact, adoption challenges, and future opportunities for automation.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Nordic Head of Automation & AI Practice at a major IT services company, with extensive experience implementing agentic AI and automation solutions for large enterprise clients, particularly in insurance and BPO sectors.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- **The expert is optimistic about the scalability and impact of agentic AI, predicting significant operational efficiencies and cost savings for large enterprises** as adoption increases.
- They believe that while agentic AI is still in early stages, **the next year will see noticeable scaling**, especially as platforms become easier to use and more organizations adopt them.
- The expert notes that **agentic AI is primarily seen as an efficiency lever** rather than a revenue generator, but expects its influence to grow across more business functions.

TAKEAWAYS

- **Agentic AI platforms, such as DeepOpinion, are enabling end-to-end automation of complex processes like insurance claims, with straight-through processing rates as high as 95% in some cases**.
- **Implementations have resulted in significant workforce reductions (up to 65% in claims processing) and substantial cost savings, with expectations of further scaling across more product lines and geographies**.
- The adoption of agentic AI is still in its early days, with only a small percentage of potential processes currently automated, but pilots in BPO operations show automation potential of 40-60%.
- **Barriers to scaling include organizational 'POC fatigue', lack of clear direction**, integration challenges, and the need for business transformation rather than treating projects as pure IT initiatives.
- Pricing for agentic AI platforms is typically consumption-based (per task), with **cost savings shared between service providers and clients, leading to higher margins for providers despite lower overall revenues**.

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Expert Bio

Nordic Head of Cognizant Automation & AI Practice at Cognizant. The expert can speak on use cases for Agentic AI as well as roadmapping for their company and clients' companies. Nordic Head of Cognizant Automation & AI Practice at Cognizant. Reporting to the Global Leader and contributing to the global leadership team. They are responsible for leveraging AI alongside automation, overseeing large-scale projects like evaluating generative AI products, implementing AI solutions for insurance customers, and leading automation and process improvement teams for clients such as Tryg, Alm. Brand, Storebrand, and Nordea Life & Pension across claims, policy servicing, finance, and marketing. They utilize tools like RPA, process mining, BPM, and agent automation (genAI) and are preparing to lead the implementation of a major claims transformation project for Allianz with Deep Opinion. Prior to Cognizant, the expert was the CEO of Another Kind of Automation (AKOA), where they led the company and oversaw various strategic initiatives. They have significant experience in operating models, automation software, and integration platforms. Additionally, they bring leadership experience from their time at BCG and have a strong consulting background. The expert can speak to the utilization of AI in order to automate various client functions.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Hi, thank you for taking the time to speak with me. For context, we're really to understand where companies are in their AI journey. It's going to be really interesting because you are working with so many clients, understanding what your point of view is on where they are, what shifts you see in the market, things like that. One thing we wanted to talk about, in the questions that you submitted, you talked about one use case in specific, which was an end-to-end claims processing, so let's start with your background and experience, and then we just want to go from there, if that sounds good.

Expert 00:00:35

Absolutely. It's for one of the largest European insurance companies. It's an agentic AI platform that we are using here. Agentic AI is a generative AI in a process automation context. How it works is in a low-code platform, you build your process flows, and then in previous generations of automation technologies like robotic process automation, for example, **you were forced or you could only work with rule-based processes via the user interface, etc**. A very brittle processes, very static, and the majority of processes were left untouched.

With agentic AI, you can then work on unstructured data in more complex and dynamic processes. I can give some examples on what that means. That is the revolution we are starting to see. It's still relatively early, so that's why I'm starting to see that this particular use case is in production. It's being scaled as well as we speak. What we have done is we have DeepOpinion in this case. They are an agentic automation platform, and there are other partners as well.

You have the hyperscalers building their own agentic AI platforms. You have the independent software vendors, the SaaS companies like ServiceNow, CRM like Salesforce, Workday, etc., then you have what I call the RPA heritage firms like Automation Anywhere and UiPath, and then you have a set of agentic AI-native firms, if you will, that have built platform straight up to do this. DeepOpinion is one example. n8n is another one. CrewAI is another one.

Client 00:02:12

I know you just named a bunch of companies. Are you using all of them for the end-to-end claims processing case?

Expert 00:02:18

No. I'm just trying to paint the scene here.

Client 00:02:21

Okay. Let's dive right into the end-to-end claims processing. I'm just really curious which of those service vendors you work with, which tech vendors are involved, and then also how agentic is it. Is there still a human in the loop, or is it fully automated? That would be really interesting.

Expert 00:02:39

Yes. We are the implementation partner, Cognizant. We do this for this European insurance company. The tech platform is DeepOpinion.

Client 00:02:48

Okay. This is used to create the model or what? I've not heard of DeepOpinion yet.

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Expert 00:02:54

No. They are not creating models. What they are doing is they have built an automation platform, a low-code platform, that helps you to automate processes using agentic AI. What they have is they are calling underlying LLMs, and that can be dynamically choosing which LLM is the best in each situation. They have algorithms for that, but they are not building their own LLM or they are not partnering with any particular LLM. That's how that works.

Client 00:03:22

Maybe to first understand the use case a little better, I know it's end-to-end claims processing, but just so I can imagine it well. Let's say, I purchase their insurance, is it like health insurance? What insurance is it?

Expert 00:03:36

Yes. This is P&C. We've done travel insurance, we've done motor claims, etc., but we're expanding that. A typical flow here, say, if you have a car accident. You send an email with an attachment of a picture of the car. You describe what happened. You supply your Social Security number, and then we have built an agent that monitors the inbox. As soon as an email is coming, you have one agent reading the email, making sense of the email, also reading any attachments and classifying that.

Based on the information there, it can either say, "Okay, this is incomplete. You need to submit maybe your ID number, or maybe you need to submit a picture, etc." Already, there, it takes a decision to send it back if need be. Most often, that's not needed. What it does, then, is that it realizes, "Okay, this is a claim because this is an inbox. This is a travel claim." It goes into the relevant system and gets your insurance policy. It reads your insurance policy and matches that against the claim to see, "Is the claim valid or not. Is it the same car as the insurance policy is covering?"

It can even look at pictures of the damaged car and match that to your description as an extra sanity check. Crucially, it includes the confidence score. In each of these, in this workflow, there are confidence score, and then we have a human in the loop if the confidence score is low enough. What we are doing is as we're adding a new insurance line or a new geography in the beginning, we have a human in the loop in order for everyone to get comfortable in the model. Also, it takes time, not a lot of time, but some time to get the STP up or the straight-through processing up.

Over time, you will have less and less of a human in the loop. Once you have confirmed the claim is valid, etc., then it can also automatically look at what are the damages. If it's just a small damage, it can initiate the payment, and it can also send back an email saying that your claim is being processed. More likely if it's a bigger sum, then it's sent to a human in the loop again, but then everything is prepared for like, "Okay, I go it," so you have the invoice from the repair shop and everything. Everything is prepared for the human in the loop, so even in those situations, you save a lot of money.

Client 00:05:55

Okay. Are there use cases where, let's say, it's a small claim, it seems to match the policy and everything seems to work out where there's no more human pressing, "Please pay," but it's like an automated payment?

Expert 00:06:09

Absolutely. That's called STP, the straight-through processing. That's one of the differences with agentic AI. With RPA automation and also to an extent BPM automation, you work on process steps rather than the end-to-end process, but here, you can work on the end-to-end process. That's even the goal, and the majority of the cases are like that.

Client 00:06:33

Wow. Can you tell us what percentage of cases is straight-through processing?

Expert 00:06:39

Yes. That depends because we're rolling it out across product lines and geographies, so they are in different systems and complexities of flows, but have some where it's above 95%. We have others where it's around 85%. Even if it's just sent to human in the loop for verification, we count that as a non-STP case. It's a quite strict definition. It's saving a lot of time.

Client 00:07:04

Got it. If you consider both STP and just with human in the loop, do you have any numbers of how many people are using this, how many transactions are being processed with it just where we're at?

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Expert 00:07:15

Yes. What we have in scope so far is close to 400 FTEs working in these claims processes. What we're seeing is that we can reduce that by 65% across these product lines. That's pretty significant. This is also interesting. Another thing we know that this insurance company is expecting eight figures in saving over the next three years due to this. This is across four regions, North America, Europe, Middle East, Australia, but it's not everything that can be done with the agentic AI for a company. This is just for, not all, but travel, event, motor, medical claims. That's the savings.

The interesting part here, and bad for us, is that for DeepOpinion, this is a seven figure ARR, annual recurring revenue, in licenses. They make a lot of license revenue on this like consumption. **It's still a great business case for the insurance companies**, but for us, it's like six figures in revenues. It's extremely different from RPA because with RPA, it was the other way around that you sold licenses maybe for €one million or more often like €500,000, and then there was €three million or €3.5 million in implementation revenues.

What we see here with agentic is that once you install these platforms, and installing these platforms really mean setting them up, convincing IT security that everything is to the T, and they have all the certifications and so on, but that's like one dialogue that has to be taken, and then you need to connect them to the underlying systems via APIs or webhooks, etc. Once you have done that and once you have trained the people, the development or the automation of these workflows, it's very easy.

You need the process experts and then you need a few consultants that know the tool so they can be helping with the trickier part. Otherwise, it's the process experts themselves, more or less, building these automations. First of all, **it's a bit bad for the IT service companies**, but I think it's interesting for the industry because that means the business case it's much easier because with RPA, for example, after a while, you got to a stage where while the implementation cost is higher than the revenues, you couldn't really find a business case here. The business case is easier.

What I'm describing here with 250 people savings, that's just the beginning, I think. We can come to other data points I have on our BPO operations. That's 50%, 60% across BPO and that's massive. I know there's a hype around AI. I personally don't think we're close to general artificial intelligence, stuff like that, but the agentic AI, it will be quite profound when it's implemented because there are many bigger organizations that will be affected.

Client 00:10:09

That's really cool. You did mention that this is not everything. There are plans to either automate other workflows or expand the features. Could you tell us a little bit more about the future plans in that regard?

Expert 00:10:21

Yes. We are not privy to everything here because we are the implementation partner, but we know that they are, first of all, covering more product lines. That's one. Even though we have rolled it out across geographies and business units, it's not all business units because this is a massive insurance company, but this is one of their subsidiaries. I don't know, but I think it will expand by a factor of at least five and maybe 10 if I look three years ahead. That's what I would guess. What we have insight in is policy servicing and additional geographies and product lines.

Client 00:10:56

What percentage is untapped?

Expert 00:10:58

It's still extremely early days. Even though we are saving 250 people with the implementation we're doing now and we're looking to scale it maybe by a factor of five to 10, that's still only a couple of percentage points of their workforce. Even if the AI development will stop or the AI capabilities, post now, I think you can probably automate at least 10%, 15%.

I know we have BPO operations, and there, we have started to pilot this as well. Our early evidence is that we can automate between 40% and 60%. Of course, that BPO operations, so that's back-office processes that have been outsourced, so you would expect a higher percentage point there. Even in normal companies like these insurance companies, I would expect their back and middle office to be automatable by at least 10%, 15%. We're talking maybe 10,000 FTEs just at this insurance company. It's absolutely massive.

Client 00:12:00

Awesome. Just in terms of features, are there any plans to expand the solution at all? Is this just implement it and done and you're just rolling it out to different business units and across the globe?

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Expert 00:12:11
How do you mean? On the implemented processes, if we're adding features there?

Client 00:12:16
Right.

Expert 00:12:17
It's a fine-tuning process. You go live with the process. When you go live, the confidence scores are a bit lower. You have more human in the loop. Maybe you are not even at the start automating the full end-to-end flow, even though that's what we're trying to do and most often do. There's a period from a couple of weeks to a couple of months where you fine-tune the model, you increase the confidence score, and you can reduce human in the loop, etc.

That is done almost as part of the go live or hypercare period. When that is done, it's not that we automatically add features. It's more like, "Okay, maybe the process is changing, their ways of working are changing, or there is a new regulatory requirement, so you need to redo the process a little bit." That is happening, but it's not that we otherwise necessarily go back.

This started like seven, eight months ago. Maybe if you ask me a year from now, then we would get back and do some other stuff or maybe add analytics and so on, but we already have a dashboard where we can see all the agents working and we get the data on throughput and exceptions and STP rate, etc. I'm sure the platform will develop in that because **we've already seen some incremental improvements in the platform during the time**, but it's not that we revisit processes, fundamentally speaking, it's more like fine-tuning.

Client 00:13:40
That's very helpful. In terms of tech vendor and service vendor, you already shared DeepOpinion AI was your automation platform and you're the implementation partner. Could you quickly run me through the tech stack, who you're working with, and then also which service vendors are involved other than Cognizant?

Expert 00:13:57
In this particular implementation case, you mean? Do you mean, in general, who we partner with?

Client 00:14:03
No. Just this particular one.

Expert 00:14:06
Okay. Here, they are using Guidewire, one of the core insurance systems. They are using Outlook, the emails we're using. They're using SAP as an ERP system. Those are the main ones. I don't have all the details, but there are also slight variations, not on this core system, but some geographies and some product lines have specialized systems that we also connect to, but those are the three main ones.

Client 00:14:34
Okay. What model did you use?

Expert 00:14:36
That, we don't really see. We know that DeepOpinion, they are connecting to the relevant LLMs underneath, but it's not that we are using Anthropic or OpenAI, etc. We know that they have all of those accessible to them, but that is dynamically allocated based on algorithms on their side. That's not something that you see in each as you run the processes or even as you implement it. You can if you want to override that. You can say that, "Well, for this particular query, we would like you to use OpenAI," for example, but that's not something we do because we don't see a reason to steer it in that direction.

Client 00:15:13
Got it. Where does the data sit? Is it on-prem or on the cloud?

Expert 00:15:18
Yes. This is a cloud-based one, and it's also within European Union borders, which is a plus for some of these jurisdictions. They have all the SOC two compliance, the GDPR compliance, and so on. They do penetration testing, etc. We are having these dialogues or doing pilots

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and early projects with others and there's always question around that. Will my data leak to somewhere else? Will it be used to train models, etc.? That's not the case.

Client 00:15:47

Understood. Why did you decide to go with DeepOpinion instead of the CrewAI or other competitors?

Expert 00:15:52

Yes. Mostly because they are based in European Union, so that actually helps a lot. Secondly, because **they are strong in insurance, so they already have a good footprint in insurance,** and it's way easier to get acceptance if you can showcase that something is done in the same industry as your client. Again, honestly, we like DeepOpinion, etc., but it's not that we're only going to work with them. We also work with the others. I think this use case I described to you is one of the most advanced one **I've seen in terms of scaling**, but we are using it working with others as well like UiPath and so on.

Client 00:16:29

Okay. Maybe real quick, why would you work with UiPath? When would you work with CrewAI? Who is strong in what?

Expert 00:16:38

Exactly. UiPath, that's one of the RPA heritage platforms, and they only released their agentic automation offering two months ago. **They are relatively weak,** and it's added as an afterthought. I wouldn't use them in a greenfield setting. I wouldn't use them if I could choose from the start. However, we have many clients that are quite invested in UiPath. They have a big RPA stack. Maybe they do some process mining with UiPath. Above all, maybe they're not looking at end to end, they're just looking to inject some agentic capabilities in their workflow building, and then absolutely, you can use the platform you're already using.

This goes for if you're using the Power platform, Power Automate. You can start using Copilot if you have Salesforce, and you want to do agentic within that sort of environment. I think it's a logical choice to choose Agentforce in that case. However, if you want to do end-to-end automation across different systems, then at least what I see now, I would prefer to look at one of the dedicated agentic automation platforms. Of course, that might change because there's a lot of movement here and investment.

With regards to n8n or CrewAI, I think **they are also good**. I haven't personally worked with them, but **I know there's a lot of buzz around them** as well. I would expect them to do, more or less, the same, maybe with some variations and maybe some slight differences in capabilities, but I don't see that it's a huge difference, at least what I've heard.

Client 00:18:07

Understood. You talked about Power Automate and their competitors across the board from Google, AWS, IBM. When would you use which of them?

Expert 00:18:16

Yes. We have clients that are heavily invested in Microsoft. For example, they have Dynamics, they have Azure, they have Power Platform. Power Platform, you have Power BI to do analytics and reporting and dashboarding and so on. You also have Power Pages and Power Apps and Power Automate. With those three, you can build automation workflows already now. You can build them like forms and flows and so on. Some organization, because Microsoft is investing quite a lot in the Power Platform, they are using that as an automation platform. What Microsoft is doing is that they are injecting Copilot as a generative AI story.

They have a Copilot for security, they have a Copilot for the Office package, or they have a Copilot for Dynamics, etc. Also, then in the Power Platform, they have like a Copilot that integrates with the Power Platform. Long story short, if you're heavily invested in Microsoft platform, then it makes sense to go with Copilot. However, I'm not saying this will always be the case, but I've not seen end-to-end process flows in an industrial setting with control board confidence scores, human in the loop, etc., with the Power Platform from Microsoft. I'm sure it's possible to build it, but it doesn't seem to be quite there yet. That's just my view of it.

Client 00:19:36

Interesting. Any other hyperscaler products that come to mind and how they're performing?

Expert 00:19:41

Yes. AWS has their offering. I haven't worked a lot with that. I don't have that many AWS customers in Northern Europe, so Benelux and Nordics, but I know they have one, and we partner with them as well. Google, they have several things. They have an Agent Development

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Kit, which is more like an open-source framework where you can build it. They have protocols, and they have Agentspace that integrates with Gemini, their LLM and then their cloud platform. They have this as well.

We have seen demos with them, and we have done some joint marketing with them. As far as I know, at least we have not gone beyond the pilots. That's pilots on individual projects. It's not because Google is not good enough or anything like that, it's just that even though I painted a picture in the beginning with this insurance company and how we're doing it end to end and scaling it and all of that is true, but it's also, I don't want to give the picture that we're doing that left and right everywhere.

We could do it from a technical point of view, but honestly, **the uptake is relatively slow if you compare it with the hype** and even with the technical possibility, I would say. There are a lot of barriers. There's a lot of noise to break through. There are lots of POCs being done. Many companies, they don't have budget. They don't have ownership. Their data is not in place. They're maybe spending a lot of time in choosing between platforms, or maybe they are changing their core system, so they're waiting a bit for that, etc.

There are many reasons, but what I'm saying is, it sounds a lot, but I think it will take three to five years before we have really penetrated most of the big enterprises as operations with agentic AI. That's what I see, at least, that it will take some time.

Client 00:21:29

Okay. Maybe if we look in the shift in the market just in terms of tech providers, comparing 2023 to 2024 to 2025, could you say what percentage is on Azure, AWS, and Google solutions throughout those years, and then what percentage is just on others?

Expert 00:21:48

Okay. Are you talking about agentic AI now?

Client 00:21:51

Let's say, AI in general. We can include GenAI in that.

Expert 00:21:57

Okay. In my region, **Azure is really strong**. **It was also strong in 2023**. The difference is 2023. That was just about the tipping point. Before 2023, moving to cloud and moving to the hyperscaler was about flexibility, upgradability, and going from on-prem to cloud. That was how the cloud journey was sold. From 2023, more or less, is when we also started to see generative AI coming. The move to cloud or the move to the hyperscaler became also a story about AI-enablement.

Now there's across-the-board realization that it's good to move to the cloud because that also puts your systems and data ready to be used. You can leverage AI on your systems and data. That shift happened, more or less, 2023, I would say, or that's shifting selling point, at least. To your question, I don't see a shift in AWS, Azure, and Google in the popularity of the three between these two years. What I see is that it's Azure and then it's Google and then it's AWS in my region, at least with my company. We serve the enterprise segment, just to be clear on that, so we're talking bigger companies here.

Generative AI came around that time, more or less. You had maybe OpenAI and their first model coming out, but in an enterprise setting, it was still very much about building bespoke AI applications using data scientists and, more or less, homegrown models, fine-tuning on lots of data, etc. What really shifted with generative AI is that you can quickly spin up, or you can quickly access these AI capabilities in a variety of use cases. I think that's a big difference in how AI is being worked on in enterprises.

Client 00:23:42

Interesting. When you think about horizontal compared to vertical, to what extent were the classic HR finance more prominent maybe in 2023? To what extent are more specialized, let's say, insurance-specific, biotech-specific solutions more in the coming? Did you see any shifts in that regard?

Expert 00:23:59

Yes. Maybe a slight shift. Again, even in 2025, like I said, it's still early days. What we see is that you can absolutely automate using agentic AI or generative AI in the support functions like F&A, and HR, and so on. The good thing there is that they have a history of automation, so they are very used to that lever. It's also at least more under the control of the CFO and also maybe the CIO, whereas **some of the core processes can be a bit messy**.

For example, in claims, you have the CIO, the CDO, but you also have a claims director. Maybe you have a claims transformation director, and then you have a claims director for travel. All of a sudden, you need to align with more people, and you need to align with business units that are core to your business, and they have a much bigger say. It's easier to start with the support function, and that's what we see

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as well still being done. It's being adopted, or at least, experimented with in the verticalized or core functions as well like supply chain management and so on. If you would push me, I would say, in F&A, maybe they are slightly ahead.

Client 00:25:09
Got it. What about types of use cases? Do you see a shift there?

Expert 00:25:13
Yes, slightly. Again, more in the talking than in the doing. I see at least a shift more towards end-to-end use cases rather than point-use cases. As per the previous question, I also see a maybe small shift towards working on core business process rather than just support functions.

Client 00:25:30
Okay. Can you give an example?

Expert 00:25:32
Yes. For example, in procure-to-pay, for a long time, most of the flow, you can automate, but then the volumes are so high. Even if you can automate 85%, the remaining 15% is a lot of manual processing. In the beginning, I would say, also in 2023, at least from a process automation point of view, agentic automation was seen as a point solution. For example, "Okay, now you can structure unstructured data and then you can work on it using RPA."

To me, that's a typical example of how you use agentic automation or generative AI as a point solution, but you're not really employing it end to end, whereas two years later, we have this agentic automation and that wasn't really a thing even two years ago. Now we are saying, "Well, we can look at the whole process end to end, procure-to-pay, for example, and then we have to reimagine it." As long as you give the agents the instructions and the SOPs and the targets of the workflow, then they can navigate, more or less, on their own. That's a big shift from a point solution to an end-to-end solution.

Client 00:26:43
That's really helpful. Would you also say instead of focusing on cost cutting, solutions are more targeting revenue generation now, so it's like the nature of use cases has shifted?

Expert 00:26:53
To an extent. **The cost-cutting case** is clearly there, and maybe we see more of it since we are also starting to do this on our outsourcing operations, like I said. There, it's very cost-conscious, it's very cost-driven. However, when we sell this, we include qualitative benefits as well. For example, they include that **the turnaround time is quicker**. They include that the compliance is higher, etc. That was already when you did RPA automation. That was an argument.

Potentially, you could use it also for revenue generating, but I see at least agentic automation is mainly, **I would say, an efficiency lever with some added benefits of compliance and scalability and turnaround** time and so on. It's mainly an efficiency lever that's how it's still perceived, I would say.

Client 00:27:41
Interesting. Would you say GenAI has more potential to contribute to revenue-generating use cases, and then **agentic is truly just a cost-cutting** measure?

Expert 00:27:51
Yes. Maybe that's a bit going slightly too far. I think in the general direction, you're right. When you think about it, agentic AI, to me, the definition there is employing generative AI in a process automation context with agents. Almost by that definition, it means that you are making **processes more efficient**. That can have some revenue potential.

If you think about only generative AI, there you have truly revenue-generating applications like in life science research or something like that. There, you could conjure up entirely new products or medications potentially via GenAI. That's on a whole different level than agentic AI. I think, directionally, I would agree with you.

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Client 00:28:32

Interesting. Let's say, if we compare 2023 to 2025, obviously, agentic is really new. Would you say 2023 was 100% GenAI? What is the split now between agentic and GenAI in terms of projects you're implementing?

Expert 00:28:50

Okay. I work at Cognizant, a big IT service company. We have a matrix organization, so we have verticals, so industry segments, and then we have horizontals. I lead the automation and AI practice. AI is so pervasive as a technology. It's not that my practice is the only one working with AI. We also have an infrastructure practice, for example, and they also work with AI, but in an infrastructure context. What I'm trying to say is that I look at AI with the lens towards automation. To me, it's mainly agentic automation. I think from an efficiency point of view, that is, again, the main lever.

Client 00:29:29

Would you say agentic is always taking an action such as the end-to-end claims processing, or is agentic, to you, also when a system flags something for prioritization, for example?

Expert 00:29:41

No, that is also agentic. You could have AI agents in infrastructure, for example, monitoring assistance performance and then flagging or resolving tickets, It's a classical example. There's no coincidence that ServiceNow, for example, which do a lot of IT service management, that they have their own agents. To me, agentic automation is when you have agents taking some kind of action based on AI, but it is in a process context, which means there is a flow in a way or a series of action.

Client 00:30:11

Okay. Lastly, if you think about off-the-shelf agents compared to customized, for example, a Salesforce agent, a ServiceNow agent compared to just, let's say, a Microsoft solution that's fully customized, do you see any shift there?

Expert 00:30:27

Yes, I do. Again, if we're talking 2023, this was not really even talked about, so it's that new. First of all, it's very interesting how everyone is jumping on this. I'm not going to call it bandwagon because that makes it sound like a trend, but they're really investing in this. To me, that is pretty clear because if I look at ServiceNow and Salesforce and Workday, for example, they are SaaS companies that have these workflows in the cloud with underlying databases. They see that agents could, in some way, replace their interfaces. They could be obsolete in some way. That's why they're investing so much in it.

There is a lot of noise there, to be honest. We don't see that much real, scaled implementations with any one of these. Where we see it is mostly agent use within their existing implemented stack. If you have Salesforce, if you use Agentforce, it tends to be in a Salesforce context. Maybe there are flows in Salesforce that are not automated or that you can use agents for and, similarly, in a ServiceNow context. I don't see them being used end to end. I'm not sure that technology is quite there yet for Microsoft. Again, this is very new.

For example, I was at the Microsoft conference last week, and then they all spoke about this. I was at another conference nine months ago, and then it was like, "Well, this is where we're heading." A year before that, it was hardly even spoken about. It's very, very recent in how AI agent is being center of their strategy or at least marketing strategy.

Client 00:32:03

Okay. I was wondering what **obstacles are still getting in the way of scaling**? I know you work with a bunch of different clients, so what is really still keeping you from scaling, and how are some of those obstacles mitigated?

Expert 00:32:15

This is super interesting. One thing is AI fatigue in organizations. AI technology that everyone can relate to, so that's the good thing. Everyone can conceptually understand that this is very powerful. That's also a good thing. All the different system providers, and we talked about a few, but there are a lot of others. They claim they do AI, right or wrong or to a different extent. There is such a myriad of options, and there's also a lot of interest in the customer organizations.

What happens is they do a lot of POCs, they do a lot of pilots, and they do these maybe uncoordinated in different ways, in different stages, in different places of the organization without a clear direction. **That can lead to POC fatigue, and it can lead to a lack of ability** to take the next step.

Concretely, we see that very, very often when we do POCs or pilots. There's a lack of follow-up action, or at least immediate follow-up action. I think that's one thing. Maybe that can be summarized as lack of direction. I think there is an executive sponsorship in the sense

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that even at the boardroom level, the stakeholders know that this is coming and it is for real and we need to adopt it, but there's a lack of, "Okay, how do we translate that into a roadmap?" That's one thing.

The other thing is even when you decide on an agent platform, you need to plug it in. That is not rocket science, but it involves your legal department, has to be reassured that everything is fine from a compliance point of view. Even if the platforms have all the certifications that you would ever want, that exercise can easily take a couple of months, easily.

You also need to connect the platform to the underlying systems via APIs. APIs, it's an application programming interface, which sounds really easy. You just plug it in, connect it to a magnet, but there's always some screwing and workarounds, etc. That will also take at least maybe two, three months, I would say, so that we're getting the platform up and running. Once you have the platform up and running, now **you have a pretty good foundation,** and you can start automating use cases.

Here, what you want to do is you want to enable your organization because if you're too reliant on people like me or consultants, then you're going to run out of steam or budget. You need to enable your organization as well, and especially your process experts, because that's how you identify new processes. This means, because this is one of our observations that we are an IT company, so we tend to think of this as an IT project, but when you think of it like an IT project, they don't usually scale.

When you think of them as business transformation projects, then I think **you have a higher chance of scaling**. There is a change management component. You need to identify stakeholders to do trainings and so on. You need to think of it as a business transformation. I have spoken to DeepOpinion about this.

Client 00:35:16

What opportunities do you see in the market? You've talked a lot about you have to see it as a transformation and stuff. Anything, maybe also from a technological side where you're saying, "Oh, this is probably going to take up a lot of value in the future"?

Expert 00:35:30

Yes. The platforms themselves are getting easier and easier to use, so that's one thing. They're already pretty easy. Most of these are being updated maybe twice per year or quarterly, with new releases. I think it will be easier and easier to use. More and more of them will be enabled with our customers, which means that more and more organizations will sit with very easy-to-use agentic automation platforms. That is then a tick in the box for wider adoption.

What I foresee is that towards the end of the year, and above all next year, **I think will be the year of scaling that** will be quite noticeable in the market. I think another thing is integration with voice. You already have that to some extent, and we all have it with our ChatGPT, etc., but there are still some more things that can be done in call centers and so on to really integrate that in an agentic fashion. When that is done, then we will see more action in call centers as well, but I think that's just maybe a smaller piece, to be honest.

Client 00:36:30

Amazing. I had a question around, like you mentioned, Cognizant using some automation, some agents internally for project delivery and things like that. Can you just describe what those agents are? What do they do? How are they built? Getting an idea of almost like the asset-based consulting, what is that trend all about?

Expert 00:36:51

Exactly. We have about 350,000 employees, 95,000 of those work in our BPO business, so business process outsourcing. That's companies outsourcing their back-office processes to us. They do that because of labor arbitrage. We would operate that out of India, and then there is a small slice of technology arbitrage as well so that we can improve the processes, we can make them more efficient, we can apply RPA and other earlier generation automation technologies.

That has run its course more or less. For the next wave of outsourcing, everyone wants to use AI agents, and we have started then to run pilots on that. For example, we use it within F&A for a Swedish media company. It's accounts receivable, accounts payable, and so on. We are looking at the processes that we are now doing manually. The processes that were entirely rule-based, they have already been automated to some extent. The remaining processes have some cognitive element, which made them not automatable before. Now with agents, as we've gone through, you can automate such processes.

Long story short, for this media company, we did a pilot in February and then we looked at accounts payable and we saw that we could automate 60% of that. That was a mature BPO client where we had run their operations for four years already. They were already optimized with the previous technology. That goes to show the level of savings we expect. The BPO industry, as a whole, is in this shift. There's a lot of talk about for future outsourcing, there will be an agentic-first approach. First, you would do agentic automation as a transformation and then on the residual, on what's left, you would outsource to India, etc. That's a whole new approach.

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Client 00:38:41
That brings a couple things. One thing you mentioned is for the media company mentioned, 60% of their existing work is now being done by agents.

Expert 00:38:51
Yes, within accounts payable.

Client 00:38:52
Correct, within that use case. With this example, I understand in the future, it'll be one of those things where, for project delivery, you'll use an agent and then you will leave it as a lead behind and you can get residuals on that. In the current state, with this example, did you guys decide that, "We want to try the agentic process," or did the client say, "Hey, **my costs are high**, is there anything you can do to reduce"? Who triggered the use of agentic in this work?

Expert 00:39:20
That's interesting. In this particular case, we are up for renewal next year. Both we and the clients knew that the renewal is around the corner. **The cost of space is too high,** and we also obviously wanted to secure our place. This was a joint idea that started last year, and then we presented it based on that as a proactive fifth in February. Now we have done the first production, and **we are scaling like that**.

Client 00:39:47
I have two more questions. One is, how are you pricing this? You mentioned **the cost was too high**. What is **the cost reduction,** and how is it being priced? Is it per task as a subscription? What's the actual mechanism, and how much are they saving?

Expert 00:40:02
Okay. The pricing is consumption-based. There is a variable cost based on your consumption. However, we needed a way to translate this into cost per FTE. With DeepOpinion, I can give you some rough numbers here. We are calculating that the average cost per FTE is less than $10,000 per year. That's the cost that we pay to the underlying agentic platform. Our revenues per outsourced FTE is above $20,000 per year.

The thing is, **we need to return about 50% of the savings to the customer** because, again, the customer knows about AI, so they expect us to implement this. **They expect to harvest a big part of the savings**. The 50%, we would expect to give back, and then all the remaining, we would pay DeepOpinion in this case, which would leave our profit. If that had been done by a human, it would be less profit. **Our revenues go down**, but our margins go up and our profit also goes up.

Client 00:41:01
Got it. What was the platform you were built upon?

Expert 00:41:04
This is, again, DeepOpinion.

Client 00:41:07
Got it. You mentioned it's consumption-based. It's consumption on what? It's per what, per task, per process?

Expert 00:41:15
Exactly. This is not very transparent, so it's per task. In the case of DeepOpinion, and this is, more or less, general, I would say, you build the workflows. Whenever you use the underlying AI, that is a task, which consumes credit. That is what triggered the cost. It's a cost for these platforms as well because they, in turn, invoke a question to the underlying LLMs, and they pay for that. That is how it works.

Client 00:41:43
It's almost like per token per credit, if you want to call it.

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Expert 00:41:46

Exactly.

Client 00:41:47

Got it. Thank you for taking the time to speak with me. Have a nice day.

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